



An ear for greatness: Over the years, Carillo has interviewed several leading players, including (clockwise from left) Martina Navratilova, Novak Djokovic, Andy Murray, Rafael Nadal, Roger Federer and Serena Williams.

SPECIAL ARRANGEMENT AND GETTY IMAGES

was no one else to talk to.

I had given the announcers every good reason why the upcoming Evonne Goolagong-Tracy Austin match was going to be good, and they liked my enthusiasm. They invited me to the booth for the whole match. Just a spare microphone in front of me. No headset, nothing. It was a fun match to call. It wasn't a big deal to me... but Mark had caught my drive — by my appearance — and remembered me.

I wasn't nervous calling a match or two for *USA Network*. I knew all the players, and I knew how they played. The money was okay, so I said yes to it, thinking it was going to be a one-shot deal. I had plenty to learn, and I was fascinated by the television end of it all. I couldn't have been more raw, but Mark kept me around, taught me things, and let me get better.

It was almost entirely an all-men crew, but I was accepted because it was women's tennis, and in that department, I knew more than the guys. It was rare that I felt out of my depth or apart from the crew. As the years went by and I started to call men's matches, a few of the guys felt I wasn't needed, which made me want to prove my worth even more. When I was with *CBS*, John McEnroe was hired, and he felt that I shouldn't keep calling men's matches. I should add that he had no interest in calling the women's matches. More than anything, he was not a fan of three

people booths. Fortunately, for me, the executive producer kept me in the mix, a decision not met well by John. Once we started, I think he realised that we worked well together, but he took convincing. It was not an easy time for me. Eventually, it normalised, but there were definitely some difficult days. I kept my head down and tried harder.

How has TV tennis broadcasting evolved since the 1970s, when you first watched it, and the 1980s, when you debuted and developed as a broadcaster, to today, when *Tennis Channel* broadcasts 24/7?

Whew. It's changed so much, and forever. In the beginning when I worked, we were sometimes on tape, for one thing. We showed matches in pieces; we commentated after the tennis was over. And we had such limited graphics. One of my very best friends, the late Leo Levin, had so much to do with better stats, analytics, and graphics.

I personally think there's often too much screen time overly devoted to numbers, replays, predictions, betting odds, and the like. Especially betting odds — I hate that. I could rant about betting in tennis for hours, and it wouldn't be pretty. And as much as I can respect the efficiency of using AI in tennis, I truly hope our sport doesn't lean on it too much. Some of AI is truly illuminating. Too much of it puts me

off. I wish Leo Levin, whom I called 'The Doctor' for his incisive diagnoses of players' games, was still around. So much of this is a matter of taste, and how TV can at once show the sport in a way that's entertaining and instructive. And to my mind, Leo had the best taste in tennis.

What were the major surprises about the evolution of pro tennis during your 55-year tennis career?

I guess it shouldn't be a surprise, really — the sport has gone from three grass court Majors to one — but the switch made a lasting, unfortunate impact on serve-and-volley tennis. So many players now play exactly the same way, mostly from the baseline, with power and spin that did not exist when I began to play this sport. More than anything, power is the coin of the realm.

Wooden racket tennis could not produce the tennis that is now commonplace. String technology has helped create shots that did not exist when I began my tennis. And facing two-handed backhands was a daunting and enormous change to serve and volleyers like me. My plan of attack had been simple — serve to the backhand, come in and knock off a volley. Mr. Hopman used to say to us, "On a big point, what would you rather do — hit a volley or come up with a passing shot?" Volley. It made sense. But two hands on the backhand made that easy equation